13

Conclusion: Language, Power, and Agency

Thus far, in this book, we have discussed numerous aspects of language use in real-life social contexts. In many of the case studies offered in the previous chapters, power of some sort, as expressed in or through language, has played an important role, even though we may have focused on other aspects of the cases at hand. Recall, for example, the following research described in earlier parts of this book.

- Don Kulick's (1992, 1998, 2019) research in Papua New Guinea on the shift away from the indigenous language of Taiap toward the lingua franca Tok Pisin in the village of Gapun highlights the power dynamics involved in religious conversion, economic transformations, and parental messaging.
- In her ethnography, *Exposing Prejudice: Puerto Rican Experiences of Language, Race, and Class*, Bonnie Urciuoli (1996) argues that the boundaries between Spanish and English in a New York Puerto Rican community are fuzzy when the socioeconomic status of the speakers is similar, as when Puerto Ricans are speaking with their African American neighbors. In contrast, when there are stark differences in the socioeconomic statuses of Puerto Ricans and the people with whom they are speaking, as when they are talking to white middle-class or upper-middle-class professionals, then the boundaries between Spanish and English are much more clearly demarcated.

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- In many of the law school classrooms that Elizabeth Mertz studied, authoritative exchanges occurred between professors and students (such as the dialogue cited near the end of Chapter 4), powerfully directing students toward a new way of reading, thinking, and being (2007a:125).
- In her study of the socially stigmatized group labeled "nerds," Mary Bucholtz (1999) looks at identity formation and power-laden relationships in a high school community of practice. Bucholtz shows how macro-level categories such as race, class, and gender are emergent in the micro-level social interactions of the individuals in complex and sometimes contradictory ways. Even the most mundane conversations, therefore, can (and should) be analyzed, Bucholtz argues, in order to arrive at a deeper understanding of how social statuses, identities, and hierarchies are maintained or transformed.
- Kendra Calhoun's (2019) study of the anti-hegemonic racial humor on the social media platform Vine presents an excellent example of how parody can critique dominant discourses.
- Shirley Brice Heath's classic book, *Ways with Words: Language, Life, and Work in Communities and Classrooms* (Heath 1983), describes the long-term, life-altering effects of the differences in how families from different communities socialize their preschool children with regard to written texts. Heath looked at both race and class dimensions to these differences and concluded that, because the mostly white middle-class families of Maintown introduced their children to ways of interacting with books that were quite similar to school practices, the Maintown children entered school well prepared to learn and interact with books in the ways that would be expected of them in school. Children from the other two communities, Trackton and Roadville, were involved in rich language socialization processes in the home before they entered school, but they were at a disadvantage when they reached school because they did not go through the same socialization process with regard to written texts.
- Graham Jones and Lauren Shweder's (2003) article, "The Performance of Illusion and Illusionary Performatives: Learning the Language of Theatrical Magic," looks closely at how a magician can create a powerful illusion through both verbal and nonverbal

actions. Talk in particular, Jones and Shweder argue, can actually shape the audience's experience of seeing because the narrative of the magician activates a frame in audience members that identifies the event not just as a magic trick but as something involving the paranormal in the form of Splookie the ghost.

- Laura Fish Somersal, who died in 1990, was the last speaker of the Native American language of Wappo (Thompson et al. 2006). As noted in Chapter 12, Somersal might not have retained her native Wappo if she had attended the Bureau of Indian Affairs (BIA) school in her area because it was official BIA policy to force students to speak only English. The long history of colonization and oppression that has characterized relationships between the US government and Native Americans has helped to make 80 percent of Native North American languages extinct or moribund (Krauss 1992:5).

Each of these examples illustrates in one or more different ways how power relations can be enacted in, by, and through language. Closely tied to this question is the way in which agency – the socioculturally mediated capacity to act – is an essential aspect of, and counterpart to, power. In a sense, then, we have been building throughout this book toward the central focus of this concluding chapter. Scholars interested in exploring any of the topics treated in earlier chapters of this book will benefit from grounding their analyses in the social theory most relevant to language, power, and agency. We therefore turn first to examine language and power theoretically and then add agency into the mix and consider the complicated, interconnected nature of language, agency, and power.

What Is Power?

"Power" is a term used frequently in both everyday conversations and dense theoretical treatises. There is far more written by scholars on the nature of power (social, political, economic, etc.) than can be reviewed here, but it is important to situate our discussion of power within the social theories that will be most helpful and relevant to the study of language in actual social contexts. Familiarity with their basic tenets will enrich and deepen any analysis of actual linguistic

interactions. Analyses that are not directly informed by such social theory often end up being indirectly informed by taken-for-granted and inaccurate assumptions and folk models regarding social power. The three approaches I have chosen to highlight in this concluding chapter are the ones that have been used most frequently and most helpfully by linguistic anthropologists to shed light on power and language: (1) the concept of hegemony as put forward by Raymond Williams, building on the work of Antonio Gramsci; (2) Michel Foucault's writings on power relations and discourse; and (3) the work of practice theorists such as Sherry Ortner, Anthony Giddens, and especially Pierre Bourdieu.[1]

Hegemony

One of the most useful terms for our purposes in understanding how power intersects with language is *hegemony*. According to Raymond Williams, a cultural Marxist who builds on the work of Antonio Gramsci, hegemony refers to a dynamic system of domination based not so much on violence or the threat of violence, or merely on the economic control of the means of production, but rather on political, cultural, and institutional influence. "That is to say," Williams writes, "it is not limited to matters of direct political control but seeks to describe a more general predominance which includes, as one of its key features, a particular way of seeing the world and human nature and relationships" (1983:145). Having military power or economic wealth can certainly lead to power, but social status and cultural dominance can also come from other sources, and hegemony is a term that helps us understand this process. Hegemony is saturated with the specific forms of inequality belonging to particular societies at particular historical moments, according to Williams, and is "… in the strongest sense a 'culture', but a culture which has also to be seen as the lived dominance and subordination of particular classes" (1977:110). Emphasizing the dynamic nature of any "lived hegemony," Williams reminds us that "it does not just passively exist as a form of dominance. It has continually to be renewed, recreated, defended, and modified. It is also continually resisted, limited, altered, challenged by pressures not all its own" (1977:112). In other words, Williams concludes, while any lived hegemony is always by definition dominant, it is never total or exclusive (1977:113).

Thus, though hegemonic (or dominant) ways of acting, talking, feeling, or being may seem overwhelmingly obligatory or simply "the (only) way things are done," Williams reminds us that these practices can change over time. There is always room within a given hegemonic system to resist or transform it. How are hegemonic ideas or practices reinforced or challenged? At least partially through language. For this reason, the concept of hegemony is a useful one as we move forward in this concluding chapter to explore the relationships among language, power, and agency.

Foucault's Power Relations and Discourse

The extremely influential French theorist Michel Foucault wrote prolifically and complexly about many aspects of power. Rather than conceiving of power as a thing or an entity possessed by individuals or institutions, Foucault's approach involves looking at *power relations*. Unlike relationships of *violence*, Foucault claims, which involve direct and immediate actions on bodies or things (such as breaking, destroying, bending, or hurting), relationships of *power* involve *actions upon others' actions*. Power in this relational sense, Foucault argues,

> is a set of actions on possible actions; it incites, it induces, it seduces, it makes easier or more difficult; it releases or contrives, makes more probable or less; in the extreme, it constrains or forbids absolutely, but it is always a way of acting upon one or more acting subjects by virtue of their acting or being capable of action. (1994b:138)

Foucault distinguishes power relations both from violence on the one hand and from voluntary consent on the other. Power is therefore, he argues, less like an open confrontation or a mutual engagement than a form of "government" – that is, the governing of one person by another through the structuring of that person's field of possible actions. The person whose actions are thus constrained or shaped remains "free," Foucault claims, with the potential to struggle or flee. Power and freedom are not mutually exclusive but are instead interwoven in a complex manner in his theory (1994b:139). Over time, Foucault maintains, power relations can result in "domination," which he defines as "a general structure of power…a strategic situation, more or less taken for granted and consolidated, within long-term confrontation between adversaries" (1994b:143). The term Foucault uses to describe such complex forms of power that are

constituted by institutions, procedures, and knowledge is "governmentality." Much of Foucault's writing involves a survey of European history and institutions to analyze particular governmental apparatuses and systems of knowledge (1994a:244).

Just as the concept of hegemony, as put forward by Raymond Williams, emphasizes the processual, dynamic nature of power, so too do Foucault's power relations direct attention to processes and actions. Even more pertinent to the subject of this chapter, Foucault notes that, "Power relations are exercised, to an exceedingly important extent, through the production and exchange of signs" – that is, through systems of communication (1994b:136). Power relations are thus deeply embedded within everyday social and linguistic interactions.

There have been numerous critiques of Foucault's definition of power, many of them focusing on the problematic implications it has for human agency (Bartky 1995; Hoy 1986). Even though Foucault states that, "Where there is power, there is resistance," he continues on to say, "and yet, or rather consequently, this resistance is never in a position of exteriority in relation to power" (Foucault 1978:95). The problem is that Foucault only vaguely explains how power is enforced or personified, and the processes of resistance remain similarly opaque. Instead, he focuses on much larger-scale "discourses" – the sets of rules and practices that allow people to produce meaningful statements in given societies at particular historical moments. For Foucault, a discourse – we might even capitalize the term as Discourse – could be said to be hegemonic. Stuart Hall describes Foucault's concept of discourse as follows:

> Discourse, Foucault argues, constructs the topic. It defines and produces the objects of our knowledge. It governs the way that a topic can be meaningfully talked about and reasoned about. It also influences how ideas are put into practice and used to regulate the conduct of others. Just as a discourse 'rules in' certain ways of talking about a topic, defining an acceptable and intelligible way to talk, write, or conduct oneself, so also, by definition, it 'rules out', limits and restricts other ways of talking, of conducting ourselves in relation to the topic or constructing knowledge about it. (2001:72)

Within linguistic anthropology more attention is usually paid to discourses (with a lower-case "d") at the micro level than to Foucault's Discourse (with an upper-case "D") at the macro level, but the two

different approaches can be profitably combined, since large-scale power relations are emergent in small-scale everyday linguistic interactions.

Practice Theory and Power

Readers should recall that *practice*, a concept introduced in Chapter 1, is one of the four key terms of this book (the other three being *multifunctionality*, *language ideologies*, and *indexicality*). Practice, which both reflects and shapes social structures of power, is, according to Sherry Ortner, any form of human action or interaction that reverberates with "features of inequality, domination, and the like in its particular historical and cultural setting" (1989:11–12; see also Ortner 1984). Not all practice theorists have foregrounded issues related to power, however. In fact, Ortner criticizes practice theorists such as Pierre Bourdieu and Anthony Giddens for being relatively uninterested in questions of power (Ortner 2006a:17). While this is somewhat true of Giddens (1979), it is less true of other practice theorists such as Marshall Sahlins (1981), and even less true, I would claim, of Bourdieu, at least in his writings about language. Indeed, Bourdieu's book, *Language and Symbolic Power* (1991), is quite centrally concerned with criticizing the influence within anthropology and sociology of the Saussurean model that "treats language as an object of contemplation rather than as an instrument of action and power" (Bourdieu 1991:37).

We shall return to Bourdieu's analysis of language and power in a moment, but first it is necessary to review some aspects of his more general social theory. In Chapter 1, we discussed Bourdieu's notion of the *habitus*, which refers to a set of predispositions or habits within individuals. These predispositions are shaped by the social structures from which they emerge, and they lead the individuals to produce actions and representations that will either reproduce or transform those social structures (Bourdieu 1977:78). Bourdieu's concept of *habitus* provides insight into how we can both shape and be shaped by our social and cultural surroundings. By emphasizing how we are *predisposed*, not *predetermined*, to act, think, and speak in certain ways, Bourdieu allows for the influence of social structures on our behavior while still leaving room for the possibility that we might act in opposition to the structures and norms that have influenced us. In this sense, the *habitus* is similar to Williams's notion of hegemony. The *habitus* has an endless capacity to generate thoughts, perceptions, expressions, and

actions – but this "conditioned and conditional freedom," Bourdieu argues, "is as remote from a creation of unpredictable novelty as it is from a simple mechanical reproduction of the initial conditionings" (1977:95). Ortner (1989:198) uses the term "loosely structured" to describe people who are thus neither completely free agents nor completely predetermined robots. The thoughts and actions generated by the *habitus* lead to differing outcomes within actual, concrete, real-life situations; sometimes the results of *habitus*-generated actions reinforce the status quo and sometimes they transform it. Though Ortner and others (myself included) have criticized Bourdieu for emphasizing social reproduction more than social transformation, his approach to practice theory is valuable because it provides us with a deeper understanding of how and why social inequalities can be reproduced, reinforced, or sometimes challenged.

Bourdieu's concept of *habitus*, and his practice theory in general, can be strengthened significantly by taking into account critiques that have been offered by scholars such as Asif Agha (2007:229–231) and Brenda Farnell (2000). Agha faults Bourdieu for claiming that the *habitus* is instilled in individuals in a top-down manner and is not transmitted through language. "There is every reason to think," Bourdieu writes, "that the factors which are most influential in the formation of the habitus are transmitted without passing through language and consciousness, but through suggestions inscribed in the most apparently insignificant aspects of the things, situations and practices of everyday life" (Bourdieu 1991:51). In contrast, Agha claims that "far from being 'transmitted without passing through language' the social life of the habitus is mediated by discursive interactions" (Agha 2007:229). In other words, it is through everyday multimodal verbal *and* nonverbal interactions – "one communicative event at a time," Agha argues – as well as through multiple metalinguistic processes (speech about language that assigns it social prestige or stigma) that the *habitus* is produced.[2]

Farnell (2000) also criticizes Bourdieu for proposing a disembodied notion of the *habitus* that seems to be a set of habitual practices that get inculcated in people unconsciously. Instead, Farnell suggests a more concrete, dynamic, and embodied process of social and linguistic actions. She illustrates the utility of this more grounded approach by providing examples from her fieldwork among the Nakota (Assiniboine) people of Montana, some of whom still use Plains Indian Sign Language, or "sign talk," in their storytelling and

rituals, and when communicating with the deaf or elderly. "In contrast with Bourdieu's talk *about* the body," Farnell writes (2000:412), "in the form of third-person descriptions of normative practices that are activated by the dispositions of a *habitus*, we have talk *from* the body, accounts of persons enacting their bodies using vocal signs and action signs in dialogic interactional processes."

Rather than undercutting Bourdieu's usefulness as a theorist, Agha and Farnell's critiques of some of Bourdieu's concepts can sharpen his theoretical insights and make them even more relevant to scholars interested in linguistic analysis. In addition to the concept of *habitus*, Bourdieu proposes another concept to describe the ways in which power differentials can be maintained or even exacerbated through habitual nonverbal behavior communicating value judgments about "appropriate" dress, bearing, manners, or posture. Bourdieu calls this *body* (or sometimes *bodily*) *hexis*, and once a particular *bodily hexis* is internalized, it can be very difficult to change. This concept is very much in keeping with the multimodal approach to embodied linguistic interactions we discussed in Chapter 2. This "hidden persuasion of an implicit pedagogy" is capable, Bourdieu says, of "instilling a whole cosmology, an ethic, a metaphysic, a political philosophy, through injunctions as insignificant as 'stand up straight' or 'don't hold your knife in your left hand'" (1977:94). As we saw in Chapter 4 when we discussed language socialization, children absorb more than just new words and grammatical structures as they are learning their native language(s); they also absorb all sorts of culturally appropriate (and often gender-specific) ways of holding their bodies when they stand, sit, walk, or talk.

An extremely important aspect of bodily hexis is the overall way of using the mouth – basically that which determines one's pronunciation. Bourdieu, following Pierre Guiraud, calls this "articulatory style," in which "the bodily hexis characteristic of a social class determines the system of phonological features which characterizes a class pronunciation" (Bourdieu 1991:86). In other words, accents and dialects index social class positioning as well as many other forms of social difference and dominance, and Bourdieu links these differences in pronunciation to the *habitus* and to bodily hexis. "Language," Bourdieu remarks, "is a body technique, and specifically linguistic, especially phonetic, competence is a dimension of bodily hexis in which one's whole relation to the social world, and one's whole socially informed relation to the world, are expressed" (1991:86).

Another concept of Bourdieu's that can be very useful in explaining ongoing social inequality, as well as occasional social change, is the notion of *doxa* – that which is taken for granted, that which is "commonsense," that which literally goes without saying (Bourdieu 1977:166–167). *Doxa* includes every social norm or cultural value that lies *outside* of the "universe of discourse or argument"; people do not debate *doxa* because it does not occur to them that there could be other ways of thinking or acting. Bourdieu contrasts *doxa* with two alternatives: *orthodoxy* and *heterodoxy*. Both orthodoxy and heterodoxy exist within the universe of discourse or argument. Orthodoxy, defined by Bourdieu, is opinion in favor of the status quo and the current alignment of powers. Heterodoxy is the opposite – that is, opinion that is against the status quo (see Figure 13.1).

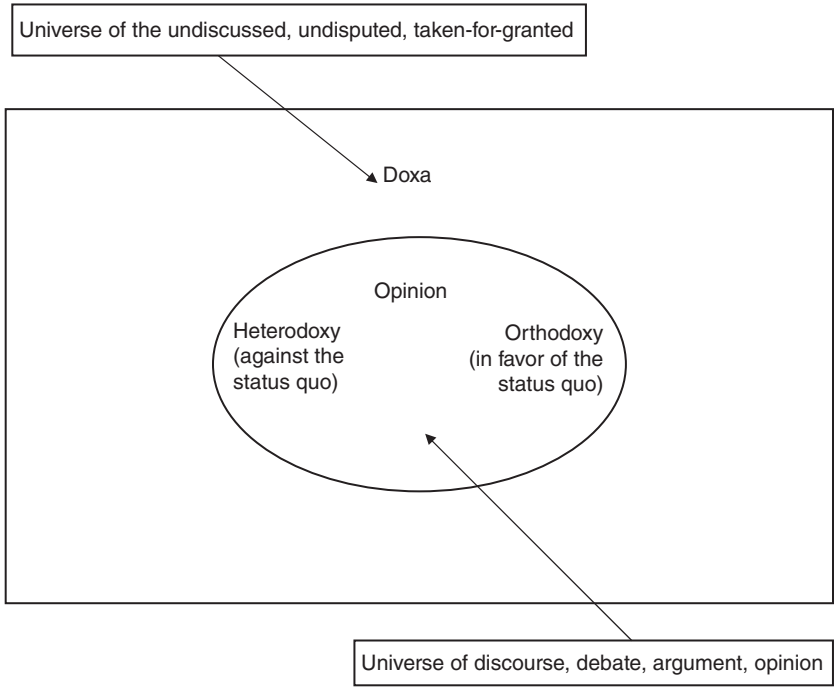


Figure 13.1 *Doxa* as that which is taken for granted and therefore outside the universe of discourse.
Source: Adapted from Bourdieu (1977:168). Used with permission of Cambridge University Press.

Take, for example, the question of gay marriage. Not too long ago in the United States (and still in many countries), it used to be a part of *doxa* that marriage was an institution that could be entered into only by one woman and one man. In recent years, however, that taken-for-granted assumption has come to be challenged, and on June 26, 2015, the US Supreme Court legalized same-sex marriage in all fifty states. Once the issue, in Bourdieu's terms, left the realm of *doxa* and entered the universe of discourse, arguments ensued. People began to take positions in favor or against the marriage of two women or two men, whereas in the past it never occurred to many in the United States that the institution of marriage might change. Eventually, same-sex marriage might become as taken-for-granted as opposite-sex marriage used to be, at which point, it would recede into the *doxa*. Other examples include how women and men wear their hair in particular societies at particular historical moments – long, short, braided, similar to each other or very different, etc. Forms of address (calling older people by their first names instead of by "Mrs.," "Ms.," or "Mr.") have also been taken for granted for certain periods of time, and then changed, with some arguments pro or con regarding whether, for example, children should call adults by their first names, or whether white adults should call African American adults by their first names, their last names, or by labels such as "boy." Clothing styles as well have been taken for granted at times and then debated at other times. Many other cultural and linguistic practices have moved from *doxa* to the universe of discourse and then back again in different societies – such is the nature of social change.

The quantities and types of practices and norms that fall within *doxa* in a given society at a given historical moment have everything to do with the maintenance or restructuring of power relations. Bourdieu notes: "The dominated classes have an interest in pushing back the limits of *doxa* and exposing the arbitrariness of the taken for granted; the dominant classes have an interest in defending the integrity of doxa or, short of this, of establishing in its place the necessarily imperfect substitute, *orthodoxy*" (1977:169). That which can be thought, said, or even debated in a particular society relates directly to relations of power and inequality within that society.

Bourdieu's writings on language go beyond *doxa* and what can or cannot be thought, said, or debated. His key contributions in this area, presented primarily in his book, *Language and Symbolic Power*, extend

his theoretical framework of practice theory to include an analysis of linguistic practices, thereby bringing questions of power and inequality to the fore. "[O]ne must not forget," Bourdieu writes, "that the relations of communication *par excellence* – linguistic exchanges – are also relations of symbolic power in which the power relations between speakers or their respective groups are actualized" (1991:37).

Drawing on terms used in economics such as *linguistic market*, *profit of distinction*, and *symbolic capital*, Bourdieu offers a way of understanding how linguistic practices can be imbued with power differentials.[3] Power relations emerge, according to Bourdieu, when the *linguistic habitus* (which is a subset of the predispositions comprising the overall *habitus*) comes into contact with the *linguistic market* (on which different ways of speaking circulate – styles, registers, accents, dialects, and languages). While this concept of *linguistic market* is quite similar in some respects to Bakhtin's notion of heteroglossia, which was discussed in Chapter 6, Bourdieu more explicitly than Bakhtin points to the varying levels of prestige associated with different ways of speaking. For Bakhtin, "All words have the 'taste' of a profession, a genre, a tendency, a party, a particular work, a particular person, a generation, an age group, the day and hour" (Bakhtin 1981a:293). But for Bourdieu, in contrast, there is a *profit of distinction* – in other words, power – to be gained from speaking in a socially valued way. The specifics of the local linguistic market will determine the outcome, so a highly educated professor, for example, may speak in a way that is well received in a doctor's office, thereby ensuring that the professor's child is given preferential treatment. The same professor, however, may be ridiculed when speaking with a group of teenagers, even – or especially – when they attempt to speak as the teens do.

Different class positions, educational or professional backgrounds, and ethnic, racial, or regional identities both shape and reflect the different communicative repertoires individuals have (cf. Agha 2007). Those who are able to speak in highly valued ways in appropriate contexts have what Bourdieu calls *linguistic* or *symbolic capital*. This sort of capital is related to ordinary economic capital (money or wealth of some sort), but not necessarily in a simplistic one-to-one way. The more economic capital one has, the more likely one will be able to acquire symbolic capital in the form of mastery of the standard dialect or competence in multiple registers or languages. In turn, such mas-

tery can often (but not always) result in greater professional success and more economic capital.

In a contribution that ties in nicely with one of this book's key concepts, that of language ideologies, Bourdieu describes how different levels of *symbolic capital* can turn into *symbolic dominance* and even *symbolic violence*. When individuals in a society are not proficient in the most highly valued ways of speaking (such as English in the United States, especially Standard American English), they do not benefit from the access such proficiency often provides to prestigious schools, professions, or social groups (cf. Lippi-Green 1997). And yet, speakers of stigmatized variants (for example, in the United States these might include speakers of nonstandard varieties of English such as African American English or Appalachian English) frequently buy into the system of evaluation that ranks Standard American English as superior. These people's own language ideologies, in other words, stigmatize the ways in which they themselves speak. This acceptance of differing social values accorded various ways of speaking is in actuality a *misrecognition*, according to Bourdieu, because the differential levels of prestige constitute an arbitrary ranking. Every language or dialect is as good *linguistically*, even though not socially, as every other.

In support of this insight that there is a *misrecognition*, or misunderstanding, of the nature of the varying levels of prestige associated with different languages or dialects, Bourdieu draws upon the work of Labov (discussed in Chapter 6), which shows that even though New Yorkers speak in many different ways, they participate in a set of shared norms, or language ideologies, that evaluate some ways of speaking as "better" than others (Labov 1972b; Bourdieu 1991:52). The result of this *misrecognition* is *symbolic violence*. And yet, by participating in these shared norms, Bourdieu controversially adds, individuals who cannot speak in the most prestigious ways are nevertheless at least somewhat complicit in their own subjugation. "All symbolic domination presupposes, on the part of those who submit to it, a form of complicity which is neither passive submission to external constraint nor free adherence to values," he writes (Bourdieu 1991:51). In this respect, Bourdieu's approach to *symbolic violence* is similar to Foucault's assertion that relations of power involve actions upon others' actions and therefore display a complex interweaving of consent and coercion (Foucault 1994b:139; cf. Ahearn 1994).

All three of these approaches to power within social theory – the concept of hegemony, Foucault's writings on power relations and discourse, and the work of practice theorists, especially Pierre Bourdieu – differ in substantial ways from the approach to power taken by most linguists. Most linguists, even including many sociolinguists, avoid talking about power altogether, preferring instead to treat language, as Bourdieu's criticism noted above claims, "as an object of contemplation rather than as an instrument of action and power" (Bourdieu 1991:37; cf. Gal 2006).

Despite the assumption often made by linguists that language is apolitical and can therefore be studied apolitically with no reference at all to differential levels of social power, the field of linguistics has itself been deeply implicated in colonialism's project of conquest and control, according to linguistic anthropologist Joseph Errington. For hundreds of years in Africa, Asia, and other places of European colonization, linguists produced dictionaries, grammars, orthographies, and other works that "made languages objects of knowledge, so that their speakers could be made subjects of power" (Errington 2008:3; cf. Bauman and Briggs 2003). Linguists who documented these non-European languages were never "just linguists," Errington argues. Instead, they were involved in using native languages for religious missionary work or as part of a "civilizing" enterprise that facilitated European control (Errington 2008:6). This is not to say that linguists did not generate useful empirical knowledge; they of course did, as Hill (2009) and others note. But neither language itself nor the study of language can ever be entirely divorced from relations of power.

Judith Irvine and Susan Gal (2000) persuasively demonstrate the linkages between language and power in an important and widely cited article that encourages scholars to study how ways of speaking come to be labeled as different from one another. How does a particular language come to be considered a language historically and politically? How, in other words, does a language like Macedonian come to be considered separate from Greek or Bulgarian? How does Serbo-Croatian come to be divided into several separate languages, such as Serbian, Croatian, and Bosnian? And what is the relationship between Urdu and Hindi, which in many places are indistinguishable verbally but which have two different writing systems and are the official languages of two different nation-states (Pakistan and India, respectively)?

Irvine and Gal provide several case studies of this sort of linguistic differentiation to illustrate the ways in which language ideologies influence both the participants (that is, the speakers) and the observers (that is, the scholars). For example, they describe how the Senegalese languages of Fula, Wolof, and Sereer were influenced by the ideologies of European linguists, ethnographers, and colonizers in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. "The way these languages were identified, delimited, and mapped, the ways their relationships were interpreted, and even the ways they were described in grammars and dictionaries were all heavily influenced by an ideology of racial and national essences," Irvine and Gal write (2000:47). Though most linguists today consider Fula, Wolof, and Sereer to be three distinct but related languages forming a "Senegal group" spoken by people in overlapping geographical areas, Irvine and Gal report that one hundred years ago, the linguistic and ethnic terrain was understood very differently (2000:48). Fula was considered by linguists to be unrelated to Wolof and Sereer, and Sereer was thought to include several Cangin languages from what is today thought to be a very different language group.

Why such a change in the understanding of these languages? Irvine and Gal argue that the answer was not so much because of better scholarship or improved data but instead because, "There have also been changes in what observers expected to see and how they interpreted what they saw" (2000:48). Nineteenth-century linguists and ethnographers assumed that linguistic classifications could be used to judge evolutionary rankings of groups. (White Europeans were of course at the top of this ranking, and various African groups clustered toward the bottom.) They also assumed that ethnic groups were monolingual and that a "primordial relationship" existed that linked languages with territories, nations, tribes, and peoples. In the case of Fula, Wolof, and Sereer, racial and linguistic ideologies led nineteenth-century linguists to consider the Fula language and its speakers (who were often lighter skinned than the others and who tended to espouse a more orthodox Islam) to be of higher status and intelligence. The Wolof language was deemed "less supple, less handy" than Fula, and its speakers less intelligent. The Sereer language, nineteenth-century linguists claimed, was "the language of primitive simplicity" (Irvine and Gal 2000:55).

While it is easy to fault previous generations of scholars for being blinded by their ideologies, Irvine and Gal caution that such ideologically influenced scholarship continues today, for, "There is no 'view from nowhere,' no gaze that is not positioned" (2000:36). Moreover, ideologically laden judgments about languages made in past centuries have had consequences that have affected how certain languages have changed, whether they have become extinct, how scholars have written grammars and dictionaries, and how political territories and identities have been claimed or mapped out. These consequences continue to affect linguistic, social, and political practices around the world, according to Irvine and Gal.

Linguistic differentiation – the labeling of a way of speaking as different from or opposed to some other way of speaking – involves three kinds of semiotic processes, Irvine and Gal maintain: (1) iconization; (2) fractal recursivity; and (3) erasure. Other linguistic anthropologists have begun to identify these processes in many different linguistic and geopolitical situations, so they are important to summarize here (Irvine and Gal 2000:37–39, cf. Woolard 2016).

- *Iconization*. Recall from Chapter 1, the discussion of Peirce's three kinds of signs: *icons*, *indexes*, and *symbols*. An *icon* is a sign that refers to its object by means of similarity, such as how a "choo choo" refers to a train, or a photograph of a person relates to the person herself. *Iconization* is a process in which linguistic features appear to be similar in some way to individual speakers or whole groups. In the case of the Senegalese languages discussed by Irvine and Gal, for example, Sereer was (mistakenly) thought by linguists to be a "primitive" language with extremely simple vocabulary and grammatical forms; this characterization was applied to the speakers of the language as well, who were, Irvine and Gal report, also considered "primitive."
- *Fractal recursivity*. When an opposition or contrast that operates at one level is projected onto another level, Irvine and Gal call this process *fractal recursivity*. An excellent example of this is provided by Stacy Pigg, who describes how her inquiries about shamans (traditional healers) in Nepal led her to a deeper understanding of how shamans are "handy symbols in the construction of 'modernity'" (Pigg 1996:161). Whenever Pigg asked a Nepali about shamans in the area, the Nepali would claim that local shamans

in that particular area (wherever she was) were not really that traditional; for "real" shamans, Pigg was always instructed to go to a place that was more "remote," "traditional," or "backward" (1996:160). Eventually, Pigg realized that her respondents were constructing themselves as more "modern" than the other places they mentioned. Just as she herself represented to them the "modern" or "developed" West in opposition to the "backward" Nepal (and I can confirm that the Nepali terms for "developed" and "backward" are often used by Nepalis themselves in this way), so too did city dwellers represent themselves as more "developed" in opposition to villagers. In turn, village dwellers, no matter how remote the village, would always present themselves as more "developed" than villagers living even further from the capital city, Kathmandu. This is a perfect example of Irvine and Gal's *fractal recursivity*.

- *Erasure*. Language ideologies can render certain linguistic features, activities, or even people invisible. Irvine and Gal call this process *erasure*. In the Senegalese example described above, nineteenth-century linguists ignored or simplified complex grammatical features in Sereer because these complexities did not fit their preconceived notion of the language as "primitive." The multilingualism of many Senegalese at the time and the overlapping nature of the linguistic terrain were also subject to erasure by nineteenth-century linguists. Similarly, the monoglot ideology dominant in the United States makes the actual linguistic diversity of the country invisible – another example of erasure. "Because a linguistic ideology is a totalizing vision, elements that do not fit its interpretive structure – that cannot be seen to fit – must either be ignored or transformed," Irvine and Gal argue (2000:38).

In all three of these processes – iconization, fractal recursivity, and erasure – linguistic differentiation is interwoven with macro-level power dynamics. But power does not just operate at macro levels. In addition to the large-scale social, political, and historical processes that Errington, Irvine, Gal, and others analyze, relations of power also operate at the more micro levels of language. In a short but very helpful essay on power, Susan Philips (2001) argues that "in anthropology today, the constitution of social reality is itself considered a form of power. Within this view, the power of language lies in its reality-

creating capacity" (2001:190). Philips identifies two other approaches to understanding the reality-creating power of language in addition to the language ideologies involved in the large-scale socio-historical processes described above: discourse and linguistic structure. First, she points to Capital-D Discourse, both in the sense of micro-level face-to-face interactions and also in Foucault's broader sense of discourse as a form of power to which we are all subordinated. Recent analyses of medical discourse by linguistic anthropologists provide good examples of how these two approaches can be merged to arrive at a better understanding of how globally circulating discursive forms and local discursive traditions intersect in actual clinical encounters (Wilce 2009:209).

Second, Philips points to the structure of language itself as an important location to study the reality-constituting power of language. Chapter 5 described many examples of how grammatical categories and semantic domains within particular languages can predispose speakers of those languages to see or think about the world in specific ways. These three areas – socio-historical processes, discourse, and linguistic structure – are three important and interrelated sites for studying the power of language to constitute reality. Philips describes their interrelationship as follows: "[T]he creation of social realities through the deployment of language structures in discourse is the process through which broader socio-historical power relations are sustained and transformed through time" (2001:192 cf. McIntosh and Mendoza-Denton 2020).

Agency

With all the discussion in the foregoing pages of rather abstract, large-scale power relations, it is easy to lose sight of the fact that power is instantiated in the actions and words of actual people in real-life social settings. The concept of *agency* was developed by social theorists as a corrective to an over-emphasis on abstract social structures, and so we turn now to a discussion of agency, especially as it is enacted in and through language.[4]

Agency is itself an abstract concept that scholars often define inadequately, if at all, but it has nevertheless become a widely used term across the humanities and social sciences. Before turning to definitional

issues, it is worthwhile to ask why so many scholars in so many fields are currently interested in the concept of agency. Ellen Messer-Davidow (1995:23) poses this question directly, asking, "Why agency now?" While there are undoubtedly many answers to this question, one is that there is a clear connection between the emergence of interest in approaches that foreground practice on the one hand, and the social movements of the 1960s and 1970s on the other (Ortner 1984:160). In addition, the social upheavals in central and eastern Europe in the late 1980s and early 1990s directly led many scholars to articulate more clearly their ideas about human agency and social structures (e.g., Sztompka 1991). As a result of witnessing or participating in actions aimed at transforming society, then, many academics began to investigate how linguistic and social practices can either reproduce or transform the very structures that shape them.

It is because questions about agency are so central to contemporary political and theoretical debates that the concept arouses so much interest – and why it is so crucial to define the term clearly. Therefore, let me present a provisional definition: *Agency refers to the socioculturally mediated capacity to act*.

This barebones definition leaves a great deal unspecified, but it serves as a starting point for further elaboration of the concept. Scholars interested in the concept might ask the following kinds of questions in order to flesh out their particular usages more precisely:

1 Must all agency be human? Can nonhuman primates, machines, technologies, spirits, or signs exercise agency, as some researchers have suggested?
2 Must agency be individual, or can agency also be supra-individual – the property, perhaps, of families, faculties, institutions, or labor unions? Some scholars, such as Wertsch et al. (1993) and advocates of Actor Network Theory (ANT) such as Latour (2005), advocate a non-individualistic notion of agency. Drawing on Vygotsky (1978, 1987) and paraphrasing Bateson (1972), Wertsch et al., for example, argue that agency "extends beyond the skin" because it is frequently a property of groups and involves "mediational means" such as language and tools (Wertsch et al. 1993:352).
3 Conversely, can agency be sub-individual, as when someone feels torn within herself or himself – the property therefore of "dividuals," to borrow the term used by McKim Marriott, Val Daniel,

Bonnie McElhinny, and others (Daniel 1984:42; Marriott 1976; McElhinny 1998:181)?

4 What does it mean to be an agent of *someone else*?

5 Must agency be conscious, intentional, or effective? What does it *mean* for an act to be conscious, intentional, or effective (e.g., Brandom 2014; Duranti 2015)?

No matter how scholars choose to answer these questions, two oft-assumed synonyms for agency – "free will" and "resistance" – must immediately be ruled out if agency is understood as referring to the sociocultural capacity to act. First, agency cannot be considered a synonym for free will because such an approach ignores or only gives lip service to the social nature of agency and the pervasive influence of culture on human intentions, beliefs, and actions. Even Charles Taylor, a philosopher whose writings on language and agency are extremely thought provoking, locates agency inside the mental processes of particular individuals rather than within broader social processes when he connects agency with "second-order desires," "strong evaluation," and "a vocabulary of worth" (Taylor 1985). Similarly, Ludwig Wittgenstein, the famous philosopher of language to whom linguistic anthropologists increasingly look for inspiration, fails to adequately theorize the sociocultural nature of language and action. While Wittgenstein (1958) recognizes the degree to which language and social forms are intertwined, he leaves the details of this interrelationship unexplained. Practice theorist Anthony Giddens notes this shortcoming in Wittgenstein's work on language and action, stating, "Wittgensteinian philosophy has not led towards any sort of concern with social change, with power relations, or with conflict in society" (1979:50).

Second, agency should not be considered a straightforward synonym for resistance. Labeling as agency *only* those actions that resist the status quo is characteristic of the work of some anthropologists, many scholars in subaltern studies, and, until recently, most feminist theorists in a number of fields. According to these researchers, in order to demonstrate agency, a person must resist existing power differentials. While one can certainly understand the impulse behind equating agency with resistance, agency should not be reduced to it. Oppositional agency is only one of many forms of agency.

Cultural anthropologists and feminist theorists such as Saba Mahmood have recently been challenging this equation of agency with resistance. In her book on the women's mosque movement in Cairo, Egypt, Mahmood (2005) argues strongly for a notion of agency that does not unreflectively reproduce culturally specific Western notions of personhood, oppression, and freedom. I agree entirely with Mahmood when she writes, "I am not interested in offering *a* theory of agency, but rather I insist that the meaning of agency must be explored within the grammar of concepts within which it resides" (2005:34; emphasis in the original). Other feminist scholars have suggested that "negative agency" is an appropriate term to describe how some women, such as the Huli of Papua New Guinea, refuse "to use their bodily energies in the ways expected of them" (Wardlow 2006; cf. Kratz 2000). Given these cross-cultural variations in the nature and types of agency, anything more precise than a barebones definition of agency runs the risk of over-generalizing notions that are actually culturally or linguistically specific.

A central task for scholars is therefore to ask themselves how conceptions of agency may differ from society to society, and how these conceptions might be related to notions of personhood and causality. Andrew Pickering suggests that "within different cultures human beings and the material world might exhibit capacities for action quite different from those we customarily attribute to them" (1995:245). Robert Desjarlais presents an illustration of this within the United States itself in his study of a homeless shelter in Boston, in which he argues that the forms of agency he observed among the shelter's residents emerged out of a specific sociocultural context. Agency did not exist prior to that context, Desjarlais maintains, but arose from within the social, political, cultural, and linguistic dynamics of the homeless shelter during a particular time period (Desjarlais 1997:204). Likewise, among the Anakalang of Indonesia, Webb Keane notes, "The relevant locus of agency – living individual, disembodied ancestor, household, faction, clan, interclan alliance – is subject to ongoing construction and transformation… Much of the work of power aims at, and is registered in, such construction and transformation" (Keane 1997:7–8). Claudia Strauss (2007) offers another example of varying ideas about responsibility and agency in the wake of the 1999 Columbine High School shooting in Colorado, in which two students killed 12 other students, a teacher, and themselves. Strauss demonstrates that

"the cultural model of persons as autonomous agents, while certainly very important in the contemporary United States, is just one of a number of cultural models Americans use to explain human action" (Strauss 2007:807–808).[5] Another cultural model common in the US, Anthea Butler noted in an analysis of the media coverage after the 2015 shooting in Charleston's Emanuel AME Church, is a racialized theory of agency in which people tend to call shooters of color words like "terrorists" and "thugs" but call white shooters "mentally ill" (Butler 2015).

Many of the scholars who have written about agency have attempted to subdivide agency into different types or categories. Ortner, for example, proposes two different but closely interrelated types of agency: the agency of (unequal) power and the agency of projects. The first kind of agency involves domination or resistance to domination and is therefore, to a large degree, defined by the terms of the dominant group, while the second kind of agency "is about (relatively ordinary) life socially organized in terms of culturally constituted projects that infuse life with meaning and purpose" (2006b:147). In agency of projects, Ortner directs us to look for how people attempt to sustain their own culturally constituted projects, often in the face of overwhelming power differentials in the form of colonialism or racism. Kockelman (2007) also identifies two types of agency: "residential agency" (involving power and choice) and "representational agency" (involving knowledge and consciousness). Likewise, Duranti (2004) has identified two different dimensions of agency in language: the performance of agency (which he subdivides further into "ego-affirming" and "act-constituting") and the grammatical encoding of agency.

All of these attempts to define, subdivide, and categorize types of agency are very useful for scholars interested in analyzing language. Duranti's two dimensions are particularly helpful. The first, the performance of agency, refers to the performative aspects of language that we discussed in Chapter 9. The second, the grammatical encoding of agency, is also very important to understand, as it is central to questions of agency in language, and so we turn now to this topic.

The Grammatical Encoding of Agency

Any discussion of agency and language must consider how grammatical categories in different languages distinguish among types of subjects,

actors, or agents, for as we saw in C`hapter 5, such categories, "to the extent that they are obligatory and habitual, and relatively inaccessible to the average speaker's consciousness, will form a privileged location for transmitting and reproducing cultural and social categories" (Hill and Mannheim 1992:387). While each language has its own set of linguistic resources that can be used to exercise, attribute, or deny agency, there are also some features that seem to be present in every language (Comrie 1981). According to R.M.W. Dixon (1994:6), for example, all languages work in terms of three basic relations – *S*, *A*, and *O* – defined as follows:

S – *S*ubject of an intransitive verb (e.g., *Sita* went to Kathmandu)
A – *A*gent, or subject, of a transitive verb (e.g., *Parvati* loves Shiva)
O – *O*bject of a transitive verb (e.g., Maya ate *rice*).

Semantically, there are various roles the subject of a sentence can take, such as the following (Duranti 1994:122–123; cf. Duranti 2004:460; Keenan [Ochs] 1984):

Agent	*Pabi* read the book
Actor	*Shiva* danced
Perceiver	*Tika* heard the news
Instrument	*The stone* broke the window
Patient/Undergoer	*The old woman* died.

These semantic roles can be treated in various ways grammatically. Defining the linguistic subject in a way that applies to all languages turns out to be a challenging and controversial topic over which linguists differ (Comrie 1981:98–101). In the majority of languages, including most of the languages of Europe, the subjects of transitive and intransitive verbs are treated the same way grammatically, while the object of a transitive verb is treated differently. This pattern is known as *accusativity*. In about a quarter of the world's languages, however, a complementary pattern obtains in which the subject of an intransitive verb and the object of a transitive verb are treated the same way syntactically, while the subject of a transitive verb is treated differently. This pattern is known as *ergativity* (Bittner and Hale 1996; Dixon 1994).[6] In ergative languages, there is usually a grammatical marker that distinguishes Agents (of transitive verbs) from Subjects

(of intransitive verbs) and Objects (of transitive verbs). This results in the potential for very different notions of subjectivity obtaining in ergative and accusative languages. Whether or not these differences exist must be determined empirically, for there is no automatic correspondence between grammatical and social agency.

Some languages have "split" grammatical systems in which speakers follow an accusative pattern in some cases and an ergative pattern in other cases. A related sort of split appears in languages that have grammatical systems in which the subjects of some intransitive verbs are categorized with transitive subjects, while the subjects of other intransitive verbs are categorized with intransitive subjects. In Guaraní, for example, the word for "I" used with more agentive intransitive verbs, such as "go" and "get up," is the same word for "I" used with the transitive verb "bring" (Mithun 1991:511). A completely different word for "I" is used with less agentive intransitive verbs, such as "to be" – the same word that is used for the direct object pronoun "me." In these languages, attributions of agency are built right into their semantic and syntactic structures.

How can the grammatical details regarding Agent, Subject, and Object in particular languages be relevant to scholars interested in the social aspects of agency? Derbyshire (1987:319) reports that in many Amazonian languages, when a highly ranked person in a transitive clause is the subject, the accusative pattern is followed, whereas when the higher ranked person is the object, the ergative pattern is followed. In English, Marianne LaFrance (1992) has shown that when subjects are asked to supply plausible scenarios of events that might have preceded and followed a set of sentences alternating male and female subjects and objects, they demonstrate a linguistic bias against women that she calls "the disappearing agent effect." Her findings indicate that if a sentence is phrased such that a female is described as doing something or feeling something, especially with respect to a male, then she fades from causal view, but when she is on the receiving end of someone else's actions, then the subject or source of these events, rather than she herself, is highlighted (LaFrance 1992:341). While these responses were elicited rather than taken from naturally occurring conversations, an ethnographically informed investigation of this phenomenon would demonstrate exactly how these linguistic usages reflect, reinforce, and sometimes reconfigure status hierarchies in the society.

Alessandro Duranti's *From Grammar to Politics: Linguistic Anthropology in a Western Samoan Village* (1994) provides just such an ethnographically rich example of how attention to what may seem like highly technical, esoteric grammatical forms can shed light on human agency. Duranti maintains that the Samoans' use of ergative markers reveals how they attribute agency socially, especially in cases of praise or blame. Powerful individuals are more likely to use the ergative marker when they want to accuse someone of a malicious act, whereas less powerful individuals try to resist such accusations by suggesting alternative linguistic definitions of events. Duranti's "grammar of praising and blaming" demonstrates how agency is expressed in, and shaped by, the linguistic forms that a socially and linguistically embedded speaker uses. Through this sort of close linguistic analysis, the links between micro and macro levels of power and agency become evident.

Talk About Agency: Meta-Agentive Discourse

Another way of analyzing power and agency in language is to look for how people *talk about agency* – how they talk about their own actions and others' actions, how they attribute responsibility for events, how they describe their own and others' decision-making processes. I have long been fascinated by this kind of talk about agency – what I have called "meta-agentive discourse," piggybacking onto the term "meta-pragmatic discourse," as used by Michael Silverstein (1976, 1993, 2001), Debra Spitulnik (2001), and others. Such talk about agency can be found in everyday mundane conversations, in narratives and life stories, in politicians' speeches, and in many other oral and written genres, including Nepali love letters, which we will discuss further below. Meta-agentive discourse can also be found in scholars' own writings (this book included, of course).

Analyzing this meta-agentive discourse can provide insight into people's own theories of agency. An example of such work can be found in Christopher McCollum's (2000) study of two different kinds of narratives he elicited from middle-class couples in the United States: (1) how they ended up with their current romantic partners, and (2) how they ended up in their current careers. In the first type of narrative, people often presented the process by which they met and fell in love with their current romantic partners as one

involving fate or chance. They just happened to go to a singles bar or answer a personal ad, they claimed, even though they "had not been looking" to get involved with anyone. In the second type of narrative, in contrast, the same individuals presented themselves as much more agentive in the process of arriving at their current professional position. They told of making active choices to major in a particular subject or apply for a certain job, even though there may have been at least some degree of luck or privilege involved in who mentored them, where they went to school, and how they happened to be hired at one place rather than another. A close analysis of meta-agentive discourse can thus bring to light differences in people's theories of agency in various areas of their lives.

Another example of how a study of meta-agentive discourse, combined with a grammatical analysis and grounded in long-term ethnographic research, can provide a deeper understanding of people's conceptualizations of their own and others' actions comes from my own work on love-letter writing in Nepal (Ahearn 2001a, 2008). As I noted in Chapter 7, love-letter writing only became possible in the Nepali village of Junigau in the 1990s because it was during that decade that most of the young women became literate, and they put their literacy skills to an unexpected use: writing love letters. The letters were about much more than love, however; they were saturated with "development discourse" (cf. Escobar 1995; Pigg 1992, 1996). The practice of sending and receiving of love letters came to be interpreted by Junigau residents in the 1990s as indexing a certain kind of person – a "developed" (*bikāsī*) person as opposed to a "backward" (*pichhyāDī*) person (and they used these exact terms).

Many social, economic, and political changes were taking place in Nepal in general and Junigau in particular during the 1990s. For our purposes here, the most relevant changes came in the ways that people conceptualized causality or responsibility for events – in other words, their theories of agency. To oversimplify quite a bit but to give a basic idea of the trend, more and more Junigau residents in the 1990s attributed events to particular individuals rather than to fate. This trend was not unidirectional, nor was it without complexities, as we shall see in the letters of Shila and Vajra excerpted below, but the trend was very evident, both to me and to the villagers themselves, who commented explicitly on the change during the years I lived in the village.

Before presenting some of Shila and Vajra's love letters, some background on their relationship is important.[7] I met Shila on the very first day I arrived in Junigau in 1982. At that time, she was a lively, skinny, mischievous little girl of 12 or so who had long since been pulled out of school in order to help her widowed mother. From time to time, Shila would attend evening female literacy classes, but often she was kept busy at home or in the fields. I met Vajra a few days after my arrival in Junigau when I started teaching at the village school. He was one of my brightest students in seventh grade English, and he eventually went on to study at the campus in the district center. In those years I never imagined that the studious, painfully shy Vajra and the vivacious, popular Shila would ever be attracted to each other. Nevertheless, by the summer of 1990, when they were both in their early twenties, it was clear to everyone in the village, including me, that they were courting.

Vajra and Shila had known each other their whole lives, but both say that it was only after they worked together on the construction of a youth club building in 1990 that they began to notice each other. In a December 1992 interview, Vajra described how afraid he used to be of girls and women; if one accidentally brushed against him, he said, he felt a current (*karant*) of electricity. Eventually, however, as his parents increased their pressure on him to marry, Vajra started thinking of what kind of person he would like his life friend (*lāiph phrend*) to be. In explaining how his courtship with Shila got started, however, Vajra eschewed agency, instead claiming that love "just happens" to people. In the same conversation, Vajra then went on to describe a phenomenon I have heard echoed in many villagers' accounts of how they started their courtships. Infatuation starts with a *dekhā dekh* – an exchange of glances. No one has to *do* anything. Thus, the village agentive theory regarding romantic love is that it is something that happens *to* people rather than something for which they themselves are responsible. Love, like other types of emotion, "befalls" or "is felt by" people (*lāgyo*). In this respect, Junigau residents' approach to agency (or lack thereof) in the realm of love resembles the research by McCollum summarized above for couples in the United States.

By the end of summer in 1990 there were many public occasions at which Shila and Vajra were quite evidently exchanging more than glances. Shila was usually the aggressor at these events, mercilessly teasing Vajra when he declined to dance or was too shy to even look

at her. Shila wrote the following letter to Vajra right around this time in their courtship:[8]

> Mother's Brother's Son, why have we started to love and love each other, have such affection for each other? I can't figure out why. Why, oh, why? If I don't see you, this heart/mind of mine starts to worry even more: where will I see you? Where will I meet you? What is that, what is that? I don't know myself… … .In this life of [seemingly] two days' length, it seems to me [that one is always asking] when and how. It seems that what one says won't necessarily happen.[9]
>
> Sometimes sunshine, sometimes rain; sometimes a river flows, sometimes it dries up. Sometimes laughter, sometimes tears; sometimes suffering, sometimes joy. This is what a person's life is like. Once a person has been born, s/he must do all kinds of things, but even… … .? And I… … .? Maybe it's because I'm extremely unlucky, I don't know – why is it that really bad things always come to me? Even when I do something well, it turns out badly. If I speak well, it comes out wrong. And to you I speak extremely badly, don't I? You might say that it doesn't seem so to you. But how meanly I have treated you! And while speaking to you, how I have spit upon you! How meanly I have treated you and spoken to you, you probably thought, haven't you… …? But don't think that way, okay? No, then again, for whatever reason when I say to myself that I won't say it, then just like that, from my mind and mouth… …[your] name comes out. Why is it that when I say I won't say something, it comes out of this mouth of mine anyway? It probably has made you extremely angry, right?…
>
> … …May we be successful, I say. What is your wish… …? Of course, even when there are wishes and desires, no one knows anything about the time and circumstances under which they will be fulfilled.
>
> But some people say that if it's their lot in life, [whatever it is] they'll do it. But it seems to me that it's up to each person's own wishes… …Even without my telling you this, you would be knowledgeable about it.

In a close analysis I conducted recently of Shila and Vajra's letters, I found a gendered difference in their conceptions of their own and others' actions – both in their explicit talk about agency in their letters and in their implicit grammatical choices. While they both mix individualistic and fatalistic notions of action in their letters, as Shila does in the letter quoted above, Shila tends to emphasize the more fatalistic notions and

tends to claim that it is not possible to achieve what one wants to achieve in life. Vajra, on the other hand, often states that any and all obstacles can be overcome. Listen to just a few examples of the many that contain meta-agentive discourse in the letters – first, two from Shila's letters:

Here is an example from a letter written by Shila in July 1990 (Letter #18, 2047–4–8):[10]

> But what to do? A person probably doesn't get to survive just because s/he says, "I will survive," and a person probably doesn't get to die just because s/he says, "I will die." And so, even though I've said, "I'm an unfortunate one; I'll die," I haven't been able to die. How very, very much suffering and sadness, how many thousands of troubles and difficulties, how many thousands of obstacles I've borne! And even though they have burnt up this heart/mind inside me and turned it into ashes and stones, I find that I'm obliged to go on living in this human world… …? Let's see what this human world will be, … … …, I write. If whatever one said became true, I would … … …you today. What to do? It seems to me that whatever one says does not necessarily become true.

And here is another excerpt from a letter written by Shila in September 1990 (Letter #27, 2047–6–12):

> I find that the world is like this: how many wishes, how many desires, how many interests, how many hopes there keep on being, but – what to do? – because of conditions and obstacles they get lost by themselves. And yet I find that it's necessary to go on living. You'll probably say, "What kinds of conditions and obstacles are there, after all?" you'll probably say, but – what to do? – it's not possible to cut one's chest open to show the obstacles and conditions that have arisen.

And indeed, Vajra writes frequently of being able to overcome all obstacles and of his belief that nothing was impossible. Here is an excerpt from a letter that Vajra wrote in June 1990 (Letter #12, 2047–3):

> Because one is human, one has to do all kinds of things – one has to walk, one has to talk. Why wouldn't all kinds of circumstances befall one in whatever group/class?? In that way, one has to be able to become part of one's family/race/group. That alone is called a human life. Whoever can mold time and circumstances during one's own lifetime – that alone is the human condition.

> These days nothing is impossible in this world. A person can do anything. I offer a prayer today to Shree Pashupatibaba that just as our love develops more and more fully, so too may it grow and develop fully in the future, may it be able to blossom and blossom. I also say today that love is for the purpose of spending one's whole life together forever; [I don't say that love is] for the purpose of separation.

And here are excerpts from two different letters that he wrote in August 1990 (Letter #21, 2047–4–15; and Letter #22, 2047–4–25):

> It seems to me that if anyone challenges us, we shouldn't retreat/run away; rather, after we show that person, s/he will give up. To laugh and to talk is in the nature of human beings. In the face of pure love, any power in the world must go down to defeat in the end, as much love as there is.

> Whenever doing anything some obstacles will always arise, but just because those obstacles arise, should we not do it? It will be necessary to complete the work with a lot of effort in order to overcome those obstacles. After beginning any kind of work, it will certainly be completed in the end; it shouldn't be left off in the middle. It must be completed. With any kind of work, what kind of circumstance is it if one talks and talks about it, then leaves it off in the middle without finishing it? Looking at what kind of manner that is, [it looks] so bad.

In Vajra's letters, therefore, we see a theory of agency that leans toward attributing to people in general and certainly to himself and Shila the ability to achieve their goals and to overcome any obstacles that arise. In Shila's letters, in contrast, there are more mentions of limitations, constraints, and fate. Many of the statements of both Vajra and Shila are gendered in very interesting ways. Though this is a partial analysis, what is clear is that there is a definite difference in Shila and Vajra's meta-agentive discourse in the letters. Their explicit remarks about their own and others' capacity to act in the world are indeed quite different.

Power and Agency In/through/by/of Language

As we have seen in this chapter and throughout the book, when language use is considered a form of social action, issues surrounding power and agency become central. When clear definitions of these

concepts are provided, social theory can have direct relevance to the study of language in real-life social contexts. The work of social theorists such as Pierre Bourdieu, Sherry Ortner, Raymond Williams, and Michel Foucault, for example, can help to deepen linguistic analyses of actual interactions. In turn, these kinds of close studies of language use can illuminate for social theorists the ways in which large-scale power relations emerge from micro-level communicative events.

The 13 chapters of this book, organized into three parts, have each demonstrated the benefits of treating language use as a form of social action that is embedded in relations of power. In the introductory chapter, four key terms were presented to help elucidate the linguistic anthropological approach to language: *multifunctionality*, *language ideologies*, *practice*, and *indexicality*. These terms have acted as a set of lenses through which the topics covered in the 13 chapters of the book could be viewed. The first part of the book, "Language: Some Basic Questions," introduced methods and approaches undergirding linguistic anthropology, focusing in particular on multimodality (Chapter 2), on how linguistic anthropologists carry out their research (Chapter 3), how they study language acquisition and socialization in children, adolescents, and adults (Chapter 4), and how they understand the complex ways in which language, thought, and culture are related (Chapter 5).

In the second part of the book, "Communities of Speakers, Hearers, Readers, and Writers," the emergent nature of global communities of practice provided a starting point for discussions of speech communities and multilingualism (Chapter 6), literacy practices within various communities around the world (Chapter 7), the online creation of identities and communities (Chapter 8), and the importance of performance and performativity for the constitution of communities (Chapter 9).

In the final part of the book, "Language, Power, and Social Differentiation," the ways in which language use is enmeshed with relations of power and agency were made explicit by focusing on language and gender (Chapter 10), language, race, and ethnicity (Chapter 11), language endangerment and death (Chapter 12), and language power, and agency (Chapter 13).

What I hope has become increasingly clear throughout the book is that linguistic anthropology as a discipline provides scholars in many different fields who are interested in social and linguistic practices

with the analytical tools and insights for investigations that extend far beyond any given utterance. As diverse and as open to borrowing from other disciplines as the field is, linguistic anthropologists share a commitment to *language as a non-neutral medium* (Duranti 2011). As the Russian literary critic M.M. Bakhtin famously noted, "The word in language is half someone else's…Language is not a neutral medium that passes freely and easily into the private property of the speaker's intentions; it is populated – overpopulated – with the intentions of others" (1981a: 293–294). Understanding the complex and inherently social nature of language requires an approach that takes into account the ways in which linguistic practices and language ideologies both shape and reflect power relations, cultural identities, and social norms. Linguistic anthropology provides such an approach to "living language."